A smart young man, he figured he could parlay a small fortune into a very big one. He set up an investment firm. He made some bets. Within a few months he had lost it all.

"You should have been happy with what you had," we suggested.

"A million doesn't do you any real good. You need real F-U money."

Our friend was a visionary. And a philosopher. And a great success. He quickly recovered, worked hard over several decades, and built a large fortune. Finally, he had F-U money.

But what is F-U money, exactly? And how much do you really need?

William Faulkner gives us a hint. When he was fired from being postmaster of Laurel, Mississippi, allegedly for drunkenness, he said he felt liberated: "I reckon I'll be at the beck and call of folks with money all my life, but thank God I won't ever again have to be at the beck and call of every son of a bitch with a 2 cent stamp."

F-U money is the money you need so that you are not at the beck and call of every son of a bitch with a 2-cent stamp. It is the amount of money you need to be free. It could be a lot or a little, depending on your ambitions. But it is the money you need so that you can do what you want.

That sounds almost egomaniacal. And there's always that risk. The man who can say "F-U" is tempted to do so. But being financially independent doesn't mean being antisocial. On the contrary, financial independence frees you to cooperate, create, and collaborate on an equal basis with others. It frees you from dependence on the government or on an employer. You have no reason to give false praise and no reason to pay sycophantic allegiance to any creed or salute any flag—unless you really believe in it. You don't have to be a "good citizen." You don't have to be a "good employee." You don't have to be a zombie.

The rich are often accused of being overly concerned with money. In our experience, it's the poor who spend the most time thinking about it. When we were poor, we had to think about how we could afford to get the radiator fixed in our old truck or how we might make ends meet if we lost our job. When we built our first house, we scrounged materials in junkyards because we didn't have the cash to buy them new. We studied the classifieds to find old cars. We saved coupons, and we knew exactly how much was in our wallet and how much gas we could buy when we stopped at a filling station.